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201 Research in the Disciplines: Technology

April 17, 2025

The Ethical Dilemma of AI Integration in the Workplace

Introduction

Artificial Intelligence, or AI, has quickly transitioned from a distant concept of fiction to being catapulted into the spotlight faster than Americans have been able to keep pace with. As AI is integrated into society, its capabilities are vast and seemingly endless, and it will continue to become increasingly prevalent in almost all areas of life for American people. Arguably the most important of all is the workplace, where AI will rapidly progress and quickly have a large role in technologically dependent jobs, and some form of role in almost all jobs in America, which could cause a lot of uneasiness at these new developments in technology. Americans are tasked with determining whether AI's integration into the workplace is a looming threat to millions or an overblown, unrealistic danger, and based on each individual's findings, determine if AI development should be supported in regards to the workplace, or if it is too much of a threat to support. Given the sheer scale of the American workforce, and the massive grasp AI will have on it, Americans must compile all aspects of information regarding this diverse and complex issue, and determine individually whether AI development is worth supporting. A botched integration of AI could result in mass job loss for millions of Americans and causing the U.S. economy to fall, while a successful integration could include the addition of Unconditional, Universal, Basic

Income (UUBI) and make Americans' lives considerably less stressful (Bruun & Duka 6).

Multiple facets greatly influence how this addition to the workplace takes place, with one being ethics. Delving into how ethical design and production of AI greatly affect the American people will be a critical aspect in this debate. Focusing on these issues, and the possible mental health effects associated with the pressure AI is and will push onto people, will also be incredibly insightful toward decision-making. James Bridle's *New Dark Age: Technology and the End of the Future*, first chapter "Chasm," depicts how the inability of people to keep up with technological developments could result in a new dark age, where humans use technology without understanding how it works, resulting in people being left in a vulnerable situation (Bridle 2). Cases such as delving into polls regarding Americans' decreasing support of AI over recent years, and which jobs are affected by AI, all factor into decision-making regarding this topic (Felten). Another prevalent case is the current legal frameworks the U.S. government has in place to control AI and protect Americans in regards to the workplace and their shortcomings. These theoretical concepts and cases relate significantly, as throughout this debate lies the question of whether AI should be supported toward incorporation into the workplace. I expect this battle will largely unfold in direct correlation with the people involved's ability to maintain ethical frameworks and transparency with the people to create and maintain trust, in addition to displaying that AI's potential and positives outweigh the negatives due to the firm grip that these governing bodies have on the issue, to prevent an AI takeover.

Understanding Technology

Beginning to understand the diverse and complex issue of AI requires starting with understanding its capabilities and potential. Given the pressing issue of AI, ignorance is

incredibly dangerous, which is why, before being capable of formulating an opinion, one must understand its capabilities. Bridle explains it best when he states, “We don’t and cannot understand everything, but we are capable of thinking it. The ability to think without claiming, or even seeking, to fully understand is key to survival in a new dark age because, as we shall see, it is often impossible to understand” (Bridle 6). Acknowledging that it is impossible for humans to fully grasp technology and the sooner we accept that but attempt to understand the concepts and basics of these developments is critical, rather than accepting ignorance. Bridle understands that in this new age of technology, making sure people are informed about how technology works is key; otherwise, a false sense of trust and vulnerability can occur. One example of this is how many people have blindly trusted an AI to answer a more complex question, only for them to get an unsatisfactory answer, as AI is closer to an encyclopedia regurgitating information given to it than an actual moral, intelligent, and human thinker. This is conveyed when Chomsky delves into conversation with a popular AI service called ChatGPT and asks the AI, “Is your moral difference immoral?” to which it responds, “As an AI, I do not have moral beliefs or the ability to make moral judgments, so I cannot be considered immoral or moral. My lack of moral beliefs is simply a result of my nature as a machine learning model. My abilities and limitations are determined by the data and algorithms that were used to train me and the specific task I was designed for” (Chomsky). Despite AI responding and acting like a human, it not only has a complete lack of morals, but also is limited to the data it is fed, which poses questions Bridle might suggest: Are we confident that the information being fed to these AIs is ethical and morally correct, or are they given information with bias and malintent? One blatant example of this that anyone can test is when you use the DeepSeek AI, which is made by a Chinese company: any question related to Taiwan will result in an answer suggesting it is a Chinese

territory, and the bot has no recollection of what happened in 1989 in Tiananmen Square.

Although the U.S. government is far less controlling and blatant biases like these don't exist, it's very tough to guarantee that a completely unbiased development strategy was used when developing these services, and this example showcases how information can be controlled through AI. One final point Bridle mentions suggests, "How we understand and think our place in the world and our relation to one another and to machines will ultimately decide if madness or peace is where our technologies will take us ... It refers to both the nature and the opportunity of the present crisis: an apparent inability to see clearly what is in front of us, and to act meaningfully, with agency and justice" (Bridle 11). Bridle is arguing humans are the creators and have the power to dictate how each piece of technology is used, and technology is only as moral and justice-bound as the person or group who created it. Understanding the morals and ethics of AI before delving into whether it will be beneficial in the workplace is essential to this problem, which is playing out in real time.

Ethics of AI & Ethical AI

Morality and ethics play a huge role in life, as people expect others to behave in moral, ethical, and rational ways. Yet, they often struggle to trust that others will do so all of the time and still keep their guard up. Despite this rational thinking, humans seemingly forget that the technology is made by humans and often let their guard down online, especially when interacting with AI. The assumption that AI is ethical correlates back to Bridle, and allowing ourselves to blindly trust these newly created machines without a slight doubt toward the information they provide feeds into his idea of the deadliness of ignorance. This is not to say that AI is inaccurate, but it's also to say that AI isn't fully accurate and does not provide morally conscious answers.

Wang and Siau explored ethical AI and how the development of AI driven by ethical principles greatly benefits the final product. They note that although AI has extremely beneficial capabilities in aspects of life such as medicine, facial recognition, and self-driving vehicles while also showcasing the ability for strong economic growth, human well-being, and safety AI is currently plagued with data-security, data-privacy, and ethical flaws (Siau & Wang 1).

Acknowledging AI's intriguing and desirable benefits while also being cautiously aware is essential to furthering its growth and successful integration into society, and Siau and Wang's proposal toward this is centered around their plan for successful AI development driven by ethics in two phases. Phase one revolves around the term "Ethics of AI," which is defined as the people creating the AI being bound by morals and ethics. Before AI can possess ethics, phase one requires the people behind the development of AI to possess these ethics first, which can be described as, "Roboethics is concerned with the moral behaviors of humans as they design, construct, use, and interact with AI agents, and the associated impacts of robots on humanity and society" (Siau & Wang 3). The importance of "Ethics of AI" is essential to creating beneficial technology and needs to have universal participation to be achieved. Companies and employees must be transparent with their developmental strategies, in addition to creating protocols to ensure AI is developed in a fair way that isn't discriminatory, and holding it to ethical uses is critical. While also having governments set regulations on AI development ensuring transparency, security and protection of Americans, allows for ethical and fair development, which allows people to feel at peace. The ability for people to view how AI is being developed and the confidence that it is ethical allows for peace of mind, as Chen writes, "Therefore, the impact of job skills demands from the perspective of AI embeddedness on employees' well-being in organizations and job performance largely depends on the extent of employees' technological

anxiety towards artificial intelligence” (Chen 3). The technological anxiety explored by Chen as a result of AI is another negative attribute of the growing concern people have around it, and by abiding by Siau and Wang’s “Ethics of AI,” trust and security can be felt, shedding the anxiety plaguing many people regarding the looming possibilities of AI. One example of how this is currently missing from AI is how criminals used AI to impersonate a CEO’s voice with the goal of having them wire massive amounts of money at his request (Siau & Wang 4). Siau and Wang argue that this shouldn’t be possible if AI is developed ethically, with clear components to stop malicious use of these tools or roboethics. Roboethics being maintained through employees, employers, and governments is fundamental to building AI that Americans can trust through transparency and understanding, as Bridle suggested, before they can confidently support the development of AI without the anxiety stemming from fear of their livelihoods and jobs being disrupted.

Phase two of Siau and Wang’s plan to bring ethics to AI is titled “Ethical AI,” and it refers to how AI interacts with humans and the ability of the developers to ensure AI is able to maintain ethical and morally correct conversations. This can be defined as AI being able to maintain explainability, accountability, privacy, and fairness simultaneously ensuring that questions are answered honestly, safely, and accurately to ensure that users are protected. One example provided that shows how AI can unintentionally deviate away from these ethics is explained when Siau and Wang write,

“Without training in human rights laws, software engineers may write codes that violate and breach key human rights without even knowing it. It is crucial to teach human rights laws to software engineers. Ensuring privacy-by-design is important and more cost-efficient than the alternatives. A better knowledge of human rights

laws can help AI designers and engineers eliminate or at least alleviate the discrimination and invasion of privacy issues in AI” (Siau & Wang 8–9).

AI is incredibly hard to develop, and even when developers don’t have any malicious intent in mind, holes in code or software can lead to unethical AI answers through a lack of awareness of human rights laws, among other factors. These issues can lead to subconscious biases in the code such as racial, sexist and other inherent biases that exist in society. Similar to how Chomsky exposed current AI systems’ lack of moral code, “Ethical AI” is heavily reliant on AI not only responding like a human but also being guided by the same human morals and ethics as well (Chomsky). Combining these principles in addition to Ethical AI showcases a drastically more secure AI that is not only designed by ethical people but also interacts with consumers in an ethical manner, preventing malicious activity from occurring, unlike in today’s time.

Current Perceptions & Potential Job Displacement

Supporting AI integration into the workplace evidently requires ethics, understanding, and trust from the American people, which begs the question: how much do they support AI integration currently? While 45% of Americans remain neutral on AI, 37% claim they’re more concerned than excited, compared to only 18% who feel more excited than concerned (Faverio). Additionally, 75% of surveyed workers claimed that they have used AI in the workplace during 2024, suggesting that many workers are already beginning to use it, yet the distrust is still present (AIPRM). AI usage in the workplace is quickly accelerating, with most workers already beginning to use it to their convenience, while still being increasingly wary of the future and how AI could begin to surpass assistance and begin replacement, by automating jobs and firing workers.

Another alarming statistic presented shows how 45% of workers worry that AI will replace them at work (AIPRM). Despite a majority of the workforce using AI to assist them, nearly half of Americans are depicted as being fearful they will be replaced, suggesting that although they're beginning to understand AI, they don't see ethical frameworks in place in order to prevent AI integration from resulting in scenarios such as mass unemployment or replacement of humans. This point is furthered in another study conducted, which polled Americans on how worried they were about data privacy when interacting with AI, which resulted in 56% being either somewhat or strongly worried, while only 25% felt slightly or strongly unworried (AIPRM). This study's thoroughness and polling questions depict how, although AI is quickly being integrated into the workplace with specific bots such as ChatGPT being at the forefront of this rapid development this is not to necessarily claim that AI is unsafe or the integration so far has been bad, but it does show theories such as Bridle's understanding of technology, in addition to Wang & Siau's ethical framework for AI, apply and so far have been unable to convince consumers of AI's positives without them being more fearful of the negatives.

Artificial intelligence's integration into the workplace will not be linear, affecting some fields massively while having relatively little to no impact on others. Professions, specifically those involved in mathematics, science, and business, such as engineers, programmers, accountants/auditors, and mathematicians, will be greatly affected by AI integration (Felten 38). Contrarily, jobs revolving around physical labor or a lack of technology, such as physical therapists and trainers, contract workers, and other blue-collar workers, shouldn't be affected by artificial intelligence's entrance into the workplace (Felten 38). Understanding the polarization of AI and how its increasing presence in the workplace will unevenly affect workers is important to formulating opinions on the matter. Similar to how people vote on a few key issues important to

them, workers in more technologically dependent jobs should prioritize AI, while workers in physical jobs might not have to worry. Bridle's suggestions of understanding technology's capabilities and making decisions based on this is an essential component of determining whether Americans should support AI integration (Bridle). Similarly, AI incorporation into technologically dependent jobs can be addressed with ethical solutions, by employing and following policies created to support humans, not replace them, in addition to transparency on how artificial intelligence will be used within the workplace, which provides these workers with the knowledge they need to formulate accurate opinions on the matter (Siau & Wang).

Unconditional Universal Basic Income

Another key case involved is Unconditional Universal Basic Income, or UUBI, which depicts how every American can receive a monthly income, reforming capitalism as we know it. One depiction of how this could potentially come to fruition is,

“Fast forward 20–30 years in the future and, based on current estimates and research, we believe that robotic labor will have started to substitute human labor en masse across most sectors of the economy. As this unfolds, governments will fall in the vicious circle of funding expanding social welfare programs (think here of unemployment benefits) with less tax revenue (consider here losses from income tax revenue)” (Bruun & Duka 1).

As artificial intelligence continues to enter the workplace and begins to take jobs, the United States must be prepared to combat this in multiple ways, with one aspect being implementing an Unconditional Universal Basic Income for its citizens. Although this scenario of mass layoffs isn't guaranteed, it is a definite possibility, which is why the United States government's

preparation and adaptability are integral to how successful this change is. Another explanation of how UUBI could be implemented is, “We believe that the introduction of an income tax on intelligent machines in the economy would constitute the best solution available. In our opinion, this can be done by first classifying robots under law as ‘technological life forms’ subject to income tax. This legal recognition would then allow a government to devise a way to extract this tax in practice. A tax on robots would not only provide the means to fund UUBI; it would indirectly decrease the labor productivity of machines and, by association, increase the chances for humans to secure employment” (Bruun & Duka 9). Recognizing that inhuman workers such as robots and artificial intelligence are subject to a tax allows governments to not only fund UUBI programs, but indirect benefits such as job creation for Americans and deterring companies from using robots as a whole allow for multiple benefits. Siau & Wang’s Ethics of AI principles about development companies having ethical frameworks and ethical workers hold true to a UUBI proposal as well. This monthly income, funded by tax dollars companies would need to pay from usage of inhuman workers, needs to be created with ethical frameworks and Americans in mind because although there are situations where UUBI isn’t required, the U.S. government needs to be prepared in case of it. Preparedness secures that as mass layoffs take place, Americans are not only financially secured, but taxes on non-human life forms could deter many companies from excessive use, allowing Americans to retain jobs. This is essential, given “The effect of artificial intelligence on the level of human employment will be severe; Frey and Osborne (2017) calculate that 47% of all jobs offered in the US economy fall in the high-risk category (i.e. jobs that are easily automatable in the next two decades).” (Bruun & Duka, 5). Comprehending that nearly half of the U.S. job market is categorized under the high risk category highlights the necessity of preparedness. Knowing the government has a plan such as

this in place to protect workers not only allows for a safe integration of AI into the workplace but provides Americans with the transparency and trust required to support this addition.

Current U.S. Legal Frameworks

The U.S. government has a pivotal role in the future of the workplace in plans such as UUBI, but also in their policies, which are the baseline for how much artificial intelligence is allowed to progress. One Executive Order, 13960, states, “Promoting the Use of Trustworthy Artificial Intelligence in the Federal Government,” and outlines two major requirements for federal agencies. The first requirement is that federal agencies adhere to nine principles when “designing, developing, acquiring, and using AI in the Federal Government. The nine principles are: (a) lawful and respectful of Nation’s values, (b) purposeful and performance-driven, (c) accurate, reliable, and effective, (d) safe, secure, and resilient, (e) understandable, (f) responsible and traceable, (g) regularly monitored, (h) transparent, and (i) accountable” (Rawal 4). This order puts forth groundwork mainly to ensure that artificial intelligence is developed in responsible and ethical ways, largely adhering to the Ethics of AI and Ethical AI principles discussed in the framework section. Another key Executive Order is 14110. This order states, “Executive Order 14110 ‘Safe, Secure, and Trustworthy Development and Use of Artificial Intelligence,’ issued on October 30, 2023, outlines eight guiding principles and priorities to advance and govern the use of AI: (a) ensure safe and secure AI technology; (b) promote responsible innovation, competition, and collaboration; (c) support American workers; (d) advance equity and civil rights; (e) protect Americans’ interests and consumer protection; (f) protect privacy and civil liberties; (g) manage risks of the federal government’s use of AI; and (h) strengthen U.S. leadership abroad, safeguarding ways to develop and deploy AI technology responsibly” (Rawal

5). Covering many aspects of potential ways artificial intelligence is capable of harming Americans and businesses, this framework lays down a very strong foundation for rules these bots must adhere to. Combining these two executive orders presents an incredibly strong foundation for the safe creation of AI and the protection of American citizens, following very closely to Ethics of AI for Executive Order 13960 and Ethical AI for 14110. Although Americans are currently protected, there is the reality that a new administration could revoke existing executive orders (Rawal 9). This flaw in the system could be very problematic if a President doesn't have Americans' best interests in mind and perhaps wants cheaper labor as opposed to mitigating job loss, causing this issue to be very important in upcoming elections. Current progression toward protecting Americans from AI by governmental policies has made great progress, and the addition of the AI Bill of Rights in 2022 has contributed to these progressions (Rawal 6). This bill confirms that AI systems are safe and effective, protects against discrimination, safeguards privacy, explains how AI is used, and provides human alternatives to AI (Rawal 6). This bill, in addition to the two executive orders, comprises the main laws toward protecting Americans from AI. Although further protections such as a plan for UUBI and increased legislation to protect Americans from being replaced by AI are still needed, these laws offer protections and codes by which AI must be developed. Referencing how important Ethics of AI is, or the assurance that AI is being developed by ethical companies and workers, the government clearly incorporated these principles, as the purpose of them is evident. Additionally, Ethical AI is also covered when they reference preventing discrimination through AI, whether consciously coded or subconsciously. Bridle's concepts of transparency and addressing privacy are also present, with laws in place to require transparent development and explanations of AI.

These laws and theories incorporate into a very strong framework for AI protections by the government.

The Potential of Mass Layoffs

A major counterargument around AI integration into the workplace is the massive potential it has for mass layoffs and replacing humans, as well as the accompanying effects. Mass unemployment is a very distinct possibility if not strategically avoided. Idoko explains this by stating, “Furthermore, the advent of big data analytics and AI-driven automation amplifies the potential implications of workforce replacement, as routine and repetitive tasks become increasingly automated” (Idoko 4). AI’s rapid integration has the potential to create massive job loss, while also widening the income gap between rich and poor. Measures need to take place in order to prevent this worst-case-scenario option from becoming reality. Not only are mass layoffs a major downside to potentially integrating AI into the workplace, but there are a multitude of side effects that come along with it. One explanation of this reads, “several key areas impacted by the increasing use of automation and technology in the workplace: Widening Economic Inequality, due to automation disproportionately affecting lower-skilled jobs; Loss of Traditional Jobs, as machines replace tasks previously done by humans; Skill Mismatch and Re-training Challenges, necessitating continual skill updates; Social Displacement and Mental Health Issues, as unemployment from automation leads to social and psychological stress” (Idoko 9). Understanding the multitude of plausible side effects of mass layoffs due to AI presents a lot of doubt toward the incorporation of it within the workplace.

However, this article, along with many others, also identifies how transparency and ethics being involved in the integration of artificial intelligence are key proponents to preventing this

situation (Idoko). Using principles from roboethics, as well as United States law through Executive Order 14110 incorporating this theory, it can be deterred that artificial intelligence is currently incapable of mass layoffs, as long as these laws are followed, as transparency and ethical development will limit how overtaking it can potentially be (Siau & Wang; Rawal). Another major flaw in this outlook is that systems such as UUBI, which have been schemed up in order to combat this scenario, are plausible solutions, although they haven't been formally created yet (Bruun & Duka). Mass layoffs are certainly a major speculation regarding artificial intelligence, but the current demand for ethics and transparency from multiple governing bodies suggests that the threat is recognized and respected to prevent this scenario from occurring.

The Lack of Privacy & Security of AI

Artificial intelligence is currently a very new technology, and questions arising regarding data breaches and lack of privacy have caused major concerns on artificial intelligence in general and its incorporation into Americans' jobs. One example of this is, "In 2021, a data breach at Clearview AI, a facial recognition company, exposed millions of scraped images, raising concerns about the unauthorized collection and potential misuse of personal data" (Abebe 2). Resulting in millions of faces being leaked through a data breach, major questions become apparent when artificial intelligence is integrated into the workplace, as companies need to be certain workers can safely use these tools without the risk of privacy breaches occurring. Company privacy is important, but protecting employees is just as critical, and immoral monitoring using artificial intelligence sparks ethical debates. GenAI has been documented for taking part in this, with a statement reading, "GenAI technologies introduce a myriad of ethical challenges, particularly within workplace environments where they are increasingly employed

for surveillance and employee monitoring. While these technologies hold the promise of enhancing productivity, security, and compliance, they also raise significant ethical concerns related to consent, transparency, fairness, and the responsible use of collected data” (Abebe 12). The Ethics of AI theory, which revolves around AI development companies creating AI based on ethical principles, contradicts this example of how artificial intelligence is currently being used in the workplace (Siau & Wang). These two examples expose massive concerns Americans need to factor in before deciding whether artificial intelligence’s benefits are worth the risks. Furthermore, other documentation of artificial intelligence usage has read, “Deepfakes have been used in creating fake videos of politicians and celebrities, spreading misinformation, and even facilitating financial fraud. This case highlights the potential for deepfakes to bypass security measures and facilitate financial fraud within organizations” (Abebe). Referencing again Siau & Wang, step two of their ethical framework for artificial intelligence revolved around Ethical AI, which ensured AI was able to interact with humans in an ethical and safe way. This is blatantly disregarded within this example, sparking concerns over the strength of AI development in terms of its capabilities regarding fraud and crime. Multiple instances of privacy being breached and security concerns plague artificial intelligence’s development and role within the workforce.

However, through the recent laws being passed with major assertion of security and privacy concerns, AI development companies will have to be more thorough than ever in validating that their bots are incapable of data breaches, privacy breaches, and illegal activity (Rawal). Another argument is that the benefits simply outweigh the concerns, as using artificial intelligence has the potential to greatly boost workers’ performance, while data breaches are extremely uncommon. Artificial intelligence is an extremely new concept, and given the risks and previous data breaches, companies designing these bots, as well as governmental bodies, are

incredibly honed in on eliminating all possible risks and threats to Americans' safety. Americans are capable of viewing artificial intelligence structurally through legal obligations for transparency, and strides taken to ensure safety mitigate these past risks from occurring in the future, ensuring artificial intelligence can safely enter the workforce.

Conclusion

Artificial Intelligence's integration into the workplace is an incredibly pressing subject, and its incorporation has proven to be largely dependent on the ethical and transparent frameworks behind it, allowing it to proceed as a benefit to American workers rather than a looming threat. Given all the presented data, I believe artificial intelligence should be integrated into the workplace, as long as ethical and transparent frameworks are maintained through United States law, as well as company accountability. Diverging into Bridle's assertion of the importance regarding understanding how technology works is a critical theory in formulating an opinion regarding AI (Bridle). It sets the precedent for the main theories of Ethics of AI and Ethical AI, which assert that artificial intelligence must be developed by ethical companies and ethical employees, who are being held to principles that lead to the successful foundation of artificial intelligence development (Siau & Wang). Furthermore, Ethical AI is a result of the previous circumstances, as ethical development leads to ethical AI, which is incapable of allowing malintent to come to fruition, as well as handling questions with human morals and code in mind (Siau & Wang). These guiding principles relate not only to AI and its development, but also to decisions being made by third parties around it. Examining cases such as current support for AI and which jobs will be affected allows the reader to gauge the current state of artificial intelligence in the minds of Americans. Additionally, examining ethically created cases

designed to prevent the drawbacks of AI in the workplace, like UUBI and current laws, gives Americans the security they need in order to commit to believing artificial intelligence has the potential to revolutionize the workplace without causing mass unemployment (Bruun & Duka, Rawal). Counterarguments such as artificial intelligence's potential for mass layoffs and previous examples of privacy and data breaches raise concerns, but given the frameworks and cases outlined, United States law and the ethical developments being maintained so far counteract these claims, which still overall support the development of artificial intelligence for the workplace.

Ultimately, the decision is up to each American, and given artificial intelligence's disproportionate potential effects on each individual, the decision varies for each person. Americans' currently appear to be losing trust in AI each additional year. However, given the multitude of cases and frameworks analyzed in this research paper, it is evident great care and caution have already occurred and will continue to in order to maintain ethical usage of AI and assure that safe integration into the workplace takes place. As long as Americans can visually see that ethics, transparency, and humans are prioritized during this integration, supporting this potentially revolutionary technology appears to be a safe decision.

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